KINDRED SIEGE

THE DROWNED CITY

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT | DEFINITIVE EDITION | v4.0

Three Pillars: AI Behaviour × Psychological Simulation × Rivalry Engine

19 Sections | 40+ Pages | Complete Design Specification

Platform: Steam PC | Premium Purchase | Charity Integration

Unity 2022 LTS (C#) | Solo Developer | MSc Digital Games (Brunel University London)
March 2026 | Confidential Working Document

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Elevator Pitch

A Lovecraftian auto-battler where you command AI-driven units against eldritch horrors that remember you, adapt to your strategies, and come back stronger. Configure your army with Pre-Built Gambits, issue Tactical Directives mid-battle, and manage your units' psychological resilience as sanity degrades under cosmic horror. A percentage of every sale and all Charity DLC revenue goes directly to a UK mental health charity.

Working Title: KINDRED SIEGE: THE DROWNED CITY

Genre: Lovecraftian Auto-Battler with Procedural Rivalry and Psychological Simulation

Platform: PC (Steam) — keyboard/mouse, Steam Deck compatible

Price: £14.99–£19.99 (premium, no microtransactions, no ads, no loot boxes)

Engine: Unity 2022 LTS (C#)

Developer: Solo developer — MSc Digital Games (Brunel University London)

Target Audience: Fans of Darkest Dungeon, Slay the Spire, Shadow of Mordor, and cosmic horror. Strategy gamers (20–40) who appreciate psychological depth and procedural storytelling.

1.1 The Three Design Pillars

Every design decision in Kindred Siege flows from three interconnected systems. Each pillar is a standalone innovation; together they create emergent gameplay no existing game offers.

Pillar 1: AI Behaviour. Units fight autonomously using behaviour trees. Players don't control units directly in combat — they shape AI beforehand with Pre-Built Gambits and intervene during battle with limited Tactical Directives. The AI is the gameplay, not a hidden system.

Pillar 2: Psychological Simulation. Every unit has a Sanity stat that degrades under stress and recovers through care. Low sanity causes hesitation, afflictions, and permanent breakdown. High-comprehension units suffer more from horror. Trauma creates phobias linked to specific rivals. This directly extends the developer's MSc thesis on psychological resilience in life simulations.

Pillar 3: The Rivalry Engine. Enemy leaders are procedurally generated with names, traits, weaknesses, and persistent memory. They remember your strategies, develop grudges, get promoted when they beat you, and can return from death as Undying horrors. Their rank determines Dread Power and Horror Rating. This creates emergent narrative without hand-authored story.

1.2 Key Innovations

Innovation	What Makes It Unique	Pillar

Pre-Built Gambits	Player programs unit AI through named tactic presets injected into behaviour trees	1
Tactical Directives	Limited during-battle commands that override AI, creating real-time decision pressure	1
Comprehension Stat	Class-specific multiplier on eldritch sanity damage — smarter units suffer more	2
Forbidden Knowledge	Investigators lose max sanity permanently per rival analysed — knowledge costs your mind	1+2
Trauma-Linked Phobias	Units develop specific fears tied to the rival trait that broke them	2+3
Dread Contest	Rival taunts are stat contests (rank vs resolve), not flat damage	2+3
Horror Rating	High-rank rivals passively drain sanity by mere presence	2+3
Rival Memory & Adaptation	Rivals counter your tactics, form grudges, and develop new traits from experience	3
Reality Mutations	Procedural rule changes per battle that stack and interact with rival traits	All
Mercy Mechanic	Permadeath moments connected to real-world charity donation	2+Charity

2. CORE GAMEPLAY LOOP

The game follows a Darkest Dungeon-inspired expedition cycle: prepare at the Hamlet, choose a path, survive the auto-battle, return with rewards or losses, and rebuild. The entire campaign is a roguelite structure of 15–20 expeditions culminating in an Arch-Rival confrontation.

2.1 The Expedition Cycle (One Loop)

1. HAMLET PHASE: Recruit and heal units at the Barracks and Sanatorium. Manage Pre-Built Gambit loadouts at the Archive. Review the Rivalry Board at the War Table. Spend Talent Points on veteran units. Check the Mercy Ledger at the Shrine.
2. EXPEDITION MAP (Lighthouse): Choose from 2–3 paths. Each path shows: the encounter type, the active Reality Mutation(s), the rival you'll face (with visible traits and rank), and the reward. Risk vs reward — harder paths yield better loot.
3. PREPARATION PHASE: Select 4–6 units. Assign 2 Pre-Built Gambits per unit from their class dropdown. Review the mutation and rival information. Confirm and deploy.
4. AUTO-BATTLE PHASE: Units deploy on a grid and fight autonomously. Player watches with speed controls (0.5x, 1x, 2x, 4x, pause). Sanity drains from combat events, Horror Rating, and prolonged fighting. Player spends Tactical Directive points (5 base) to intervene at critical moments.
5. THE MERCY DECISION: When a unit reaches 0 HP, battle pauses. The player sees the unit's name, class, expedition history, and traits. Spend a Mercy Token to revive them (30% HP, +15 sanity) or let them die permanently.
6. POST-BATTLE: Rivalry Engine updates — rivals remember outcomes, gain traits, get promoted or scarred. Units gain XP and stress. Loot earned. Fatigue applied to deployed units. Return to Hamlet.

> **Design Principle**
> The player's skill is expressed BEFORE and AROUND the battle — team selection, Gambit configuration, path choice, and Directive timing — not through direct unit control.
> The battle is the consequence of preparation. This is what makes it an auto-battler with strategic depth rather than a passive spectacle.

2.2 Campaign Structure

- Each run lasts 15–20 expeditions across 4–5 Districts, culminating in an Arch-Rival boss.
- Permadeath: when units die, they're gone forever. Veterans with invested Talent Points are devastating to lose.
- Meta-progression between runs: Mythos Exposure carries forward, unlocking powerful Gambits and harder rivals.
- Certain Undying rivals can persist across runs — long-term emergent antagonists.

3. THE HAMLET

The Hamlet is the player's home base — a battered coastal settlement on the edge of the Drowned City. Not a full city-builder; a focused hub with 6 upgradeable buildings, each serving a specific gameplay function. Each building upgrades 3 times using expedition resources.

Building	Function	Upgrade Path
The Barracks	Recruit new units. Roster expands with upgrades.	Unlock higher-tier classes, larger roster cap, faster recruitment
The Sanatorium	Heal stress. Restore sanity between expeditions.	Faster recovery, treat Afflictions, treat Phobias (Level 3)
The War Table	View the Rivalry Board. Track rivals, traits, grudges.	Reveal weaknesses (L1), predict spawns (L2), reveal rival mutations (L3)
The Archive	Manage Pre-Built Gambits. Unlock new tactics.	Larger Gambit pool, class-specific advanced Gambits, 3rd Gambit slot (L3)
The Lighthouse	Choose expedition path. Unlock new Districts.	Reveal mutations (L1), scout rival info (L2), reveal hidden paths (L3)
The Shrine	Mercy Token hub. View the Mercy Ledger.	Bonus Mercy Tokens per expedition, Ledger milestones, community tracker

The Hamlet grows visually as buildings improve — from ruined structures to fortified, lantern-lit havens. This visual progression contrasts with the cold alien Drowned City and provides screenshot-worthy moments for devlogs.

4. PLAYER INTERACTION: GAMBITS & DIRECTIVES

These two systems replace the card system from earlier GDD versions. Pre-Built Gambits handle pre-battle AI configuration. Tactical Directives handle during-battle intervention. Together they give the player meaningful agency before AND during combat without breaking the auto-battler format.

4.1 Pre-Built Gambits

Before each expedition, the player assigns 2 Pre-Built Gambits to each unit via a simple dropdown menu. Each Gambit is a named, pre-packaged behaviour tree branch that injects at the top of the unit's AI priority list.

How It Works Under the Hood

- Each Gambit is a C# method returning a BTNode (Sequence or Selector).
- When the player selects a Gambit, the code takes that pre-built BT branch and injects it at Priority 1 or 2 in the unit's behaviour tree.
- The unit's default class behaviour remains as a fallback below the Gambit priorities.
- No visual node editor, no drag-and-drop — just a dropdown menu calling existing BattleActions.cs nodes.
- Buildable in 1 day using existing architecture.

Example Gambits (Warden Class)

Gambit Name	Behaviour	Unlock
Hold the Line	Stay at initial position, attack anything in range, never advance	Default
Protect the Weak	IF ally HP < 30%, move to shield them and draw aggro	Default
Hunt the Leader	Target highest-HP enemy (rival proxy), ignore others	Archive L1
Reckless Abandon	Ignore all retreat thresholds, charge nearest enemy, +15% damage, -5 sanity/tick	Archive L2
Iron Bulwark	Reduce incoming damage by 30%, movement speed halved, taunt all enemies in range	Talent Tree
Vengeful March	Prioritise any rival with a Grudge against this unit's team. +20% damage vs grudge holders.	Archive L3

Each of the 8 unit classes has 6–10 unlockable Gambits. Players start with 2–3 per class and unlock more through Archive upgrades and the Talent Tree. This gives long-term progression through expanding tactical options.

4.2 Tactical Directives (During-Battle Commands)

The player starts each battle with 5 Directive Points (upgradeable via War Table). During the auto-battle, clicking a unit and selecting a Directive forces an immediate AI override. Points don't regenerate — once spent, the rest of the battle is pure AI.

Directive	Cost	Effect
Focus Fire	1	All units target the clicked enemy for 8 seconds
Hold Position	1	Unit stops moving, attacks anything in range for 10 seconds
Fall Back	1	Unit retreats to rear of grid immediately
Unleash	2	Unit ignores retreat thresholds, +20% damage for 10 seconds, costs 5 sanity
Sacrifice	3	Unit charges strongest enemy, deals 2x damage, dies at end of charge
Invoke Mercy	Token	Spend a Mercy Token to revive a fallen unit (30% HP, +15 sanity)

Strategic Depth

5 points forces brutal prioritisation. Spend 3 on a Sacrifice early to eliminate a rival, and you only have 2 left for emergencies. Save all 5 for the final phase and risk losing units to preventable deaths. The Directive economy IS the during-battle strategy layer.

5. PSYCHOLOGICAL SIMULATION (PILLAR 2)

This system directly implements the developer's MSc thesis: "Psychological Resilience in Life Simulations." It is the deepest and most interconnected pillar, touching every other system in the game.

5.1 The Sanity System

Sanity Range	State	AI Effect
80–100	Resolute	Full effectiveness. May gain Virtues under pressure.
50–79	Stressed	10% chance per tick to hesitate (skip AI action). Slight accuracy reduction.
25–49	Afflicted	25% hesitation. Gambits may partially fail. Random negative behaviours.
1–24	Broken	50% hesitation. 40% chance per tick to cower and retreat. Severe AI disruption.
0	Lost	Permanently consumed by madness. Removed from roster. Triggers -20 sanity to all witnesses.

5.2 Sanity Triggers

What Causes Sanity Loss

- Witnessing an ally die: -15 sanity (multiplied by AllySanityLossMultiplier for empathic classes)
- Being attacked by eldritch enemy: -5 per hit (multiplied by Comprehension)
- Rival taunt (Dread Contest): variable damage based on rival rank vs unit resistance
- Horror Rating aura: -2 to -8 per 5 seconds based on rival rank (multiplied by Comprehension)
- Ritual Gambits: variable sanity cost per use
- Prolonged combat: -3 per round after round 5
- Witnessing a unit go Lost: -20 to ALL surviving units on both sides
- Passive drain (Vessel class only): -1 per second

What Restores Sanity

- Resting at the Sanatorium: +20–40 per rest cycle
- Healer units (Occultist) during combat: +5 per heal action
- Victory: +10 to all surviving units
- Killing a rival who previously defeated your unit: +25 (revenge bonus)
- Mercy Token save: +15 to the saved unit
- Herald's Courageous aura: +10 to nearby allies every 8 seconds
- Unit Bonds: +5 when bonded partner is within range

5.3 The Comprehension Stat

Not all units process horror equally. Comprehension is a per-class float multiplier applied to ALL eldritch-source sanity damage. High-Comprehension units understand the horror — and pay the price. Low-Comprehension units are too simple to be afraid.

Class	Comprehension	Rationale
Warden	0.6 (Low)	Simple soldier. Doesn't think deeply. Reduced horror impact.
Marksman	0.8 (Medium)	Focused on targets, not cosmic implications.
Occultist	1.3 (High)	Understands the Mythos. Pays the price.
Berserker	0.5 (Very Low)	Pure instinct. Barely registers what they're fighting.
Investigator	1.5 (Very High)	Actively comprehends everything. Maximum vulnerability.
Shadow	0.7 (Low-Med)	Operates on instinct and training.
Herald	1.1 (High)	Empathic awareness extends to the cosmic.
Vessel	1.0 (Baseline)	Standard. Already doomed by other means.

Thesis Connection: Cognitive Appraisal

Comprehension models the psychological concept of "appraisal" — how individuals evaluate the significance of a stressful event. Research shows that cognitive appraisal is a stronger predictor of PTSD than the event itself. High-Comprehension units appraise horror more accurately and therefore suffer more — mirroring the clinical finding that awareness amplifies trauma.

5.4 Forbidden Knowledge Trade-off

Every time an Investigator uses the AnalyseTarget action to reveal a rival's weakness, their MaxSanity permanently decreases by 2–3 points. This reduction persists across the entire campaign and cannot be healed.

- Cap: maximum reduction of 40 points (MaxSanity cannot drop below 60% of base).
- Veteran Investigators (5+ expeditions) lose 1 point less per analysis.
- Creates a depreciating-asset dynamic: the Investigator becomes more valuable for intel but more psychologically fragile with each use.
- At some point, the player must retire the Investigator or accept the risk of losing them to madness.

5.5 Trauma-Linked Phobias

When a unit's sanity drops below 50 and an Affliction is rolled, the system checks what caused the most sanity damage this battle and generates a specific phobia tied to that source.

Trigger	Phobia	Effect
Broken by rival with Rage trait	Fear of Rage	2x sanity damage from any enemy with Rage
Broken by rival with Ambusher trait	Fear of Ambush	-10 extra sanity at battle start
Broken by witnessing ally die	Fear of Death	-30 instead of -15 from ally deaths
Broken by rival's taunt (Grudge)	Fear of [Rival Name]	3x sanity damage from that specific rival
Broken by prolonged combat	Battle Fatigue	Sanity drain starts at round 3 instead of 5
Broken by witnessing unit go Lost	Fear of Madness	Panics and retreats 5 sec if any unit reaches Broken state
Broken by Horror Rating aura	Cosmic Dread	2x sanity damage from all Horror Rating auras

- Phobias persist across expeditions. They do not heal naturally.
- Sanatorium Level 3 can treat phobias (costs resources + 1 full rest cycle).
- Phobias can stack — a unit broken twice by different causes carries two phobias.
- A unit with 3+ phobias is considered Traumatised and should be retired or treated.

Thesis Connection: Classical Conditioning & Exposure Therapy

Phobias model classical conditioning — associating a specific stimulus with trauma.
Re-exposing a phobic unit to their trigger mirrors exposure therapy.
If they survive and gain a Virtue, the game models successful therapeutic outcome.
If they break further, it models re-traumatisation. Both are psychologically authentic.

5.6 Virtues and Afflictions

When sanity first crosses below 50, the system rolls for a stress trait. Veterans (5+ expeditions) have a 30% Virtue chance vs 10% for rookies — modelling the thesis finding that resilience grows from repeated stress exposure.

Type	Name	Effect
Affliction	Paranoid	AI targets allies as threats 15% of the time
Affliction	Hopeless	AI retreat threshold raised to 50% HP
Affliction	Selfish	Ignores heal/support orders, self-preservation only
Affliction	Irrational	Random targeting — ignores all priority systems

Virtue	Stalwart	Immune to further sanity loss this battle
Virtue	Focused	+25% damage, AI at peak efficiency
Virtue	Courageous	+10 sanity to all nearby allies every 8 seconds
Virtue	Resolute	Cannot drop below 1 HP for 10 seconds

6. THE RIVALRY ENGINE (PILLAR 3)

Procedurally generates, tracks, and evolves enemy leaders across encounters. Creates emergent narrative through algorithmic memory — the game's core differentiator.

6.1 Rival Generation

Component	Generation Method	Example
Name	Two-part Lovecraftian generator (name + epithet)	Vhaal the Drowned, Skrix Hollow-Eye
Rank	Starts at Grunt. Promotes on player defeat.	Grunt → Lieutenant → Captain → Overlord
Traits (2–4)	Random from base pool. Adaptive traits earned from memory.	Rage, Tactical, MarksmanHunter, Grudge
Weakness (1)	Random. Exploitable by player.	Flanking, Fire, Light, Isolation, Disruption
Memory	Logs every encounter with player.	Defeated player 2x. Scarred by Marksmen.
Grudge Target	Set when rival kills a player unit.	Grudge against "Elara" (Marksman)
Visual	Scars, size, colour based on history.	Missing eye. 1.3x size from 2 promotions.

6.2 The Dread Contest

Rival taunts are stat contests, not flat damage. An Overlord taunting a Broken unit is devastating. A Grunt taunting a Resolute Warden is ignored.

Dread Contest Formula

Rival Dread Power = Base (by rank) + Trait Bonuses + Grudge Bonus
Unit Resistance = (Current Sanity / 10) + Comprehension Modifier
Sanity Damage = max(0, Dread Power - Resistance) × 2

Damage > 20: unit gains 3-second Hesitation Lock (cannot act)
Damage > 35: phobia check triggers (if relevant phobia exists, it activates)

Rank	Base Dread	With Grudge	With Vendetta
Grunt	5	8	7
Lieutenant	10	15	13
Captain	18	25	22

Overlord	28	38	33
Undying (any)	+10 bonus	+15 bonus	+12 bonus

6.3 Horror Rating

High-rank rivals passively drain sanity from ALL player units by their mere presence on the battlefield.

Rank	Horror Rating	Drain per 5 Sec	Range
Grunt	0	None	N/A
Lieutenant	1	-2 sanity	Entire battlefield
Captain	2	-4 sanity	Entire battlefield
Overlord	4	-8 sanity	Entire battlefield
Undying (any)	+2 bonus	Added to rank	Entire battlefield

- Drain multiplied by unit's Comprehension stat.
- Multiple rivals stack: Captain (2) + Lieutenant (1) = -6 per tick before Comprehension.
- Visual: screen edges darken, chromatic aberration, low bass rumble.

6.4 Rival Lifecycle

7. SPAWNED: New rival with procedurally generated traits. Rank: Grunt.
8. ENCOUNTERED: Player fights rival. Outcome recorded in memory.
9. PROMOTED (rival wins): +1 rank, +1 new trait, +20% HP, +10% damage, +0.15 size.
10. SCARRED (rival barely survives): Gains scar, develops counter-traits to what hurt them.
11. DEFEATED: Dies. Drops unique loot. May trigger Vendetta from a subordinate rival.
12. RETURNED (rare, 12% chance): Previously defeated rival returns as Undying. +50% HP. Minimum Captain rank.

6.5 Rival Memory & Adaptation

- Defeated by Marksmen → gains MarksmanHunter trait (prioritises killing Marksmen).
- Defeated by Ritual Gambits → gains EldritchResistant trait.
- Kills a player unit → forms Grudge against that unit type. Taunts them specifically.
- Avoided 3+ times → gains Bold trait. Starts ambushing.
- Ally killed by player → subordinate rival gains Vendetta trait. More aggressive.

7. REALITY MUTATIONS

Procedural rule changes that alter fundamental game mechanics per battle. Mutations are presented on the Expedition Map at the Lighthouse, allowing the player to evaluate risk vs reward before choosing a path.

7.1 Mutation Stacking

- Initiate (Mythos 0–10): 1 mutation per battle
- Acolyte (11–25): 1–2 mutations
- Scholar (26–45): 2 mutations
- Adept (46–70): 2–3 mutations
- Seer (71+): 3 mutations, one hidden until battle starts

7.2 Four Mutation Families

Tide Mutations (Movement/Spatial)

- “THE DEEP CALLS” — All units pulled toward grid centre (1 unit/tick)
- “CURRENTS SHIFT” — Every 15 sec, all unit positions shuffle by 1–2 cells
- “DROWNED GROUND” — Bottom 2 rows deal 3 sanity damage/tick
- “RISING WATERS” — Playable grid shrinks by 1 row per side every 30 sec

Mind Mutations (Sanity/Psychology)

- “FEAR IS POWER” — Sanity damage converts to +damage bonus for 5 sec
- “MADNESS SPREADS” — When a unit gains an Affliction, a random ally also gains one
- “CLARITY IN PAIN” — Units below 25 sanity have 0% hesitation (the broken become focused)
- “MEMORIES BLEED” — Veterans start with sanity equal to their lowest from previous expedition

Flesh Mutations (Combat/HP)

- “PAIN IS SHARED” — 30% of damage dealt also hits nearest ally
- “DEATH FEEDS LIFE” — When a unit dies, all survivors heal 20% HP
- “IRON BLOOD” — Armour doubled, healing halved
- “THE WOUNDED STRIKE HARDER” — Units below 50% HP deal +40% damage

Void Mutations (Rivalry/Existential)

- “THE RIVAL KNOWS” — Rival reads your first Gambit slot and counters it (it fails)

- “NAMES HAVE POWER” — Units with phobias matching rival traits take 3x sanity damage
- “DEATH IS UNDONE” — Defeated enemies have 25% chance to respawn at 50% HP
- “THE WATCHER SEES” — Tactical Directives cost double points

7.3 Expedition Map (Risk vs Reward)

At the Lighthouse, the player sees 2–3 paths. Each shows the mutation(s), the rival, the encounter type, and the reward. Harder paths yield better loot. Players evaluate the mutation-rival combination to find paths that suit their team.

- Example: Path A shows “FEAR IS POWER” + a rival with Ambusher trait (dangerous combo). Reward: Rare Gambit unlock.
- Path B shows “IRON BLOOD” + a Fearful rival (manageable). Reward: Standard resources.
- The player running a Berserker-heavy team might take Path A because Berserkers thrive on taking damage.

7.4 Rival Resonance

Mutations interact with rival traits to create unique tactical puzzles. The system checks if the active mutation amplifies any of the rival’s traits:

- “BLOOD IN THE WATER” (all units move 50% faster) + Ambusher rival = rival crosses the map instantly
- “FEAR IS POWER” + rival with Horror Rating 4 = your units take massive sanity damage that converts to a damage bonus, creating a race between psychological breakdown and killing power
- The procedural mutation + procedural rival = a unique combat puzzle every battle

7.5 Arch-Rival Domain Expansion

At Mythos Exposure 100+, the Arch-Rival’s specific Reality Mutation is active across the ENTIRE game — every battle, not just encounters with the Arch-Rival. The player can’t avoid the mutation; they must hunt down and kill the Arch-Rival to break it.

- Example: Undying Overlord projects “DEATH IS MADNESS” globally. Every unit that dies in any battle goes Lost instead, causing -20 sanity to everyone.
- This forces the player to build a team specifically designed to hunt the Arch-Rival and end their domain.

8. UNITS

Units are the player's expedition members. Each has a procedurally generated name, a class, stats, a sanity level, a behaviour tree, and (for veterans) a Talent Tree. Permadeath makes attachment real.

8.1 Unit Classes (8 Classes)

Class	Role	Default AI	Sanity Trait	Reactive Skill
Warden	Tank	Engage nearest, protect allies	High base. Hard to break.	Brace: 30% counter-attack on melee hit
Marksman	Ranged DPS	Keep distance, focus weakest	Medium. Panics if flanked.	Snap Shot: auto-fires when enemy enters range
Occultist	Healer	Heal most damaged ally	Low. Sees too much.	Psychic Recoil: 25% chance to deal 5 sanity dmg to attacker when taking sanity loss
Berserker	Melee DPS	Charge strongest, never retreat	Gains sanity from kills.	Blood Rage: +5% damage per hit taken (stacks 5x)
Investigator	Debuffer	Analyse rivals, reveal weakness	Very low. Curious mind.	Insight Flash: 20% auto-analyse on being hit (costs 2 sanity)
Shadow	Assassin	Circle to rear, target leaders	Loner. Immune to ally death.	Vanish: untargetable for 3 sec when below 40% HP (once per battle)
Herald	Buffer	Mid-range, boost ally sanity	Empathic. 2x ally stress.	Martyrdom Pulse: +8 sanity to all allies when dropping below 50% HP (once)
Vessel	Mercy Spec	Flee. Surviving = Mercy Tokens.	Cannot be healed. Drains.	Death Denied: 20% chance to survive lethal hit at 1 HP (once)

8.2 Unit Progression

- Units gain 1 XP per survived expedition. XP unlocks Talent Tree points.
- Veteran status at 5+ expeditions: 30% Virtue chance (vs 10% for rookies).
- Permadeath: units that die or go Lost are gone forever. Talent investment is lost.
- Units can be named by the player after their first expedition.

9. TALENT TREE

Each unit class has 10 talent nodes in two branches of 5. Units earn 1 talent point per survived expedition. A veteran with 8 expeditions has 8 points to spend across both branches.

9.1 Branch Structure (Warden Example)

Resolve Path (Psychological Durability)

- Node 1: +10 max sanity
- Node 2: Comprehension reduced by 0.1
- Node 3: Immune to first Affliction roll per battle
- Node 4: Ally death sanity loss halved (-7 instead of -15)
- Node 5: Passive aura — nearby allies take 25% less Horror Rating drain

Frontline Path (Combat Power)

- Node 1: +15% HP
- Node 2: +10% damage
- Node 3: Armour blocks first sanity hit too (absorbs 5 sanity damage, once per battle)
- Node 4: Taunt — enemies prioritise this unit for 5 seconds at battle start
- Node 5: Heroic Sacrifice — on death, allies gain +10 sanity instead of losing -15

Why This Matters

Talent Trees make veteran units dramatically more valuable than fresh recruits.
This raises the stakes for permadeath and the Mercy Token decision.
A unit with 8 invested talent points is agonising to lose.
Each path reflects Pillar 2: Resolve Path builds psychological resilience,
Frontline Path builds combat capability. The choice mirrors the thesis question:
does strength come from endurance or from power?

10. ENCOUNTER TYPES & DISTRICTS

10.1 Encounter Types

Not every battle has the same “kill them all” objective. The Expedition Map shows the encounter type for each path.

Encounter	Objective	Best Classes
Annihilation	Eliminate all enemies. Standard combat.	Warden, Berserker, Marksman
Survival	Hold out for 60 seconds against endless waves. Can’t win by killing.	Herald, Occultist, Warden
Extraction	One unit carries an artefact across the grid. Enemies try to stop them.	Shadow, Marksman (escort)
Rival Hunt	Kill the rival leader (at the back, protected, taunting). Fodder flees when rival dies.	Shadow, Investigator, Berserker
Escort	Protect a Vessel as it crosses the battlefield. Vessel death = loss.	Warden, Herald, Occultist
Sanity Siege	No physical combat. Both sides project psychological attacks. First team fully Lost loses.	Herald, Occultist, high-Resolve units

10.2 Districts

The Drowned City is divided into 4–5 districts, each controlled by a rival faction with a dominant mutation family. Clearing all rivals in a district liberates it, unlocking a permanent Hamlet upgrade.

District	Theme	Dominant Mutation Family	Hamlet Unlock
The Harbour	Flooded docks, sunken ships, tidal ruins	Tide Mutations	+1 Directive Point per battle
The Asylum	Collapsed sanatorium, maddened spirits	Mind Mutations	Sanatorium upgrade: treat 2 units simultaneously
The Foundry	Industrial wreckage, twisted metal, fire	Flesh Mutations	Barracks upgrade: +2 roster slots
The Cathedral	Eldritch temple, void energy, cosmic horror	Void Mutations	Archive upgrade: unlock Tier 3 Gambits
The Abyss (final)	The deepest ruin. Arch-Rival’s domain.	All families (random)	Campaign completion

11. EMERGENT GAMEPLAY SYSTEMS

11.1 Unit Bonds

Units that survive 3+ expeditions together become Bonded. This is a counter, not a scripted event.

- Bonded units: +5 sanity when within range of each other during battle.
- If one Bonded partner dies: survivor takes -25 sanity instead of -15 (the loss hits harder).
- Creates dilemmas: send both (Bond bonus but risk cascade) or split them (safe but weaker).

11.2 Rivals Targeting Low-Sanity Units

Rivals with the Tactical trait actively prioritise low-sanity player units. They know the broken ones will flee or attack allies. This connects Pillar 3 (rivalry AI) to Pillar 2 (psychological state) — your mental weakness becomes a tactical vulnerability.

11.3 Event Cascades

The most memorable moments are chain reactions across systems:

13. Ally dies → teammates lose -15 sanity
14. One teammate drops below 50 → Affliction roll → gains Paranoid
15. Paranoid unit attacks ally → that ally takes damage
16. Damaged ally is a Herald → empathic trait = double sanity loss
17. Herald drops below 50 → Virtue roll → gains Courageous
18. Courageous aura restores sanity to the Paranoid unit
19. Paranoid unit stabilises and stops attacking allies

Seven systems interacting. No scripted sequence. Pure emergence.

11.4 Fatigue System

Units deployed on consecutive expeditions gain Fatigue: -10% all stats per consecutive deployment. Two consecutive = -20%. Three = -30% and forced rest. This prevents “best team every time” and forces roster rotation.

12. ENVIRONMENTAL HAZARDS

The battle grid includes hazard tiles that affect units standing on them. No walls or cover (avoids pathfinding complexity). Hazards are generated per district.

Tile Type	Effect	District
Deep Water	-3 sanity/tick. 2x movement cost. “Drowned Compass” Relic-holders immune.	Harbour
Eldritch Ground	Active mutation effect is 2x for any unit standing here.	Cathedral
Shrine (1 per map)	+2 sanity/tick. Immune to Horror Rating. Contested ground — usually centre of map.	All

13. MYTHOS EXPOSURE (META-PROGRESSION)

Campaign-level stat that only goes up. Tracks total immersion in the eldritch. Higher exposure unlocks power but escalates danger. Carries across runs.

13.1 What Increases Exposure

Event	Exposure	Note
Complete any expedition	+1	Baseline
Defeat a rival	+2	Studying the dead
Defeat an Overlord	+5	Major entity
Defeat an Undying rival	+8	Defying death
Lose a unit to Lost	+3	Witnessing madness
Use a Ritual Gambit	+1 per use	Forbidden power
Investigator analyses rival	+1 per analysis	Knowledge costs
Explore new district	+2	Deeper truths

13.2 Tier Progression

Tier	Threshold	Unlock (Benefit)	Escalation (Cost)
Initiate	0–10	Base game	Normal difficulty
Acolyte	11–25	Tier 2 Ritual Gambits	Rivals spawn +1 trait, Grunt HP +10%
Scholar	26–45	Tier 3 Rituals. Investigator analyses 2 traits.	New rivals start at Lieutenant rank
Adept	46–70	Tier 4 Rituals. New district: The Abyss.	Undying chance doubled. Faster adaptation.
Seer	71–100	See rival weaknesses without analysis.	All rivals have Horror Rating. -10 max sanity on recruits.
Beyond	100+	Maximum power.	Arch-Rival Domain Expansion active. Rivals spawn as Overlord.

14. THE MERCY MECHANIC & CHARITY MODEL

No ads. No pay-to-win. The charity model works through three revenue streams on Steam.

14.1 Mercy Tokens (In-Game)

- Rare resource earned through gameplay: Vessel survival, Shrine upgrades, Mercy Cards, Arch-Rival defeats.
- When a unit hits 0 HP, battle pauses. Player sees unit's full history.
- Spend 1 Mercy Token: unit revives at 30% HP with +15 sanity.
- No token: unit dies permanently.
- Mercy Ledger on main menu tracks total lives saved across all playthroughs.

14.2 Charity Revenue Streams

Stream 1: Base Game Donation

- 10–15% of every sale donated to partnered UK mental health charity.
- At £14.99 with 10% after Steam's 30% cut: ~£1.05 per sale.

Stream 2: Charity DLC Packs (£2.99–£4.99)

- Cosmetic DLC where 100% of developer revenue goes to charity.
- "The Mercy Collection" — skins, Hamlet themes, card backs.
- Clearly labelled: "All proceeds donated to [Charity Name]."

Stream 3: Community Milestones

- Global Mercy Ledger: all players' token usage aggregated.
- Milestones (100k lives saved) trigger bonus donations and in-game events.
- Creates press moments: "Kindred Siege players save 100,000 lives, donating £1,000 to Mind."

14.3 Charity Partners

- Mind (mind.org.uk) — UK's leading mental health charity
- Safe In Our World — mental health charity for the games industry
- CALM — suicide prevention
- SpecialEffect — gaming accessibility charity

15. ACCESSIBILITY

Mandatory for Steam release. Low effort, high impact, professional standard.

- Colorblind Mode: Three palettes (Protanopia, Deuteranopia, Tritanopia). Global colour ScriptableObject swap.
- Key Remapping: Full rebinding via Unity Input System. All Directives, speed controls, menus.
- UI Scaling: 75%–150% slider. Canvas Scaler with global multiplier. Essential for Steam Deck.
- Screen Reader Support: All names, states, mutations readable as text. On-screen announcements for Virtues/Afflictions.
- Speed Controls: 0.5x, 1x, 2x, 4x, pause, step mode (advance one tick at a time).
- Difficulty Options: Standard, Forgiving (-30% sanity damage, 7 Directives), Merciless (+30%, no Mercy Tokens, 3 Directives).
- Subtitles: All rival taunts, sanity events, lore. Adjustable text size.

16. ART DIRECTION

- Stylised low-poly 3D with heavy atmospheric lighting. Darkest Dungeon’s mood in 3D.
- Colour palette: deep teals, sickly greens, bruised purples, gold for the Hamlet.
- Fog and particles: volumetric fog, floating ash, distant tentacles in skybox.
- Units: readable silhouettes with class-distinct shapes. No detailed faces needed.
- Hamlet: warm, lantern-lit — visual contrast to the cold Drowned City.
- UI: PC-first, mouse-driven with keyboard shortcuts. Tooltips on everything.

Phase	Art Level	Approach
Prototype (M1–3)	Primitive shapes, colour coding	Focus on gameplay. Already working.
Alpha (M4–7)	Low-poly asset packs	Unity Asset Store, itch.io, Kenney.nl
Demo (M8–11)	Custom or commissioned models	8 unit models, 6 buildings, key VFX

17. STEAM PLATFORM FEATURES

17.1 Achievements (10)

Achievement	Condition
First Blood	Win your first auto-battle
Old Grudge	Defeat a rival who killed one of your units
They Remember	Encounter a rival promoted 3+ times
Unbreakable	Unit gains a Virtue 3 times across expeditions
The Drowned King Falls	Defeat your first Arch-Rival
No One Left Behind	Complete a campaign with zero unit deaths
100 Lives Saved	Use 100 Mercy Tokens across all playthroughs
Into the Abyss	Have a unit reach 0 sanity and become Lost
Domain Breaker	Defeat an Arch-Rival during Domain Expansion
They Never Stay Dead	Encounter an Undying rival

17.2 Steam Deck

- Full controller support with radial menu for Directives.
- UI scales to 1280x800. All text readable at native resolution.
- Target 30 FPS. Low-poly art keeps performance light.
- Cloud saves via Steam Cloud.

17.3 Store Presence

- Tags: Auto Battler, Roguelite, Lovecraftian, Strategy, Psychological Horror, Indie
- Capsule art: lantern-lit hamlet against massive tentacled silhouette rising from dark water
- Key selling point: “Your enemies remember. Your units break. Every purchase helps.”
- Charity badge visible on store page.

18. 11-MONTH DEVELOPMENT ROADMAP

Phase 1: Core Battle + Gambits (Months 1–3 | April–June 2026)

- Month 1: Health bars, battle HUD, 8 unit classes, reactive skills, Comprehension stat, Horror Rating. [IN PROGRESS]
- Month 2: Pre-Built Gambit system (dropdown UI, 3–4 Gambits per class), Tactical Directives (5-point system), environmental hazards.
- Month 3: Sanity system with Virtue/Affliction rolls, Forbidden Knowledge, Trauma-Linked Phobias. Fatigue system.

Visa evidence: Weekly devlogs. AI architecture article. GitHub active with CI/CD.

Phase 2: Rivalry Engine + Campaign (Months 4–7 | July–October 2026)

- Month 4: Dread Contest, rival memory adaptation, grudge system, Rivalry Board UI.
- Month 5: Reality Mutations (4 families, stacking), Expedition Map at Lighthouse, Rival Resonance.
- Month 6: Hamlet hub (6 buildings, upgrade progression), Talent Tree (10 nodes, 2 branches per class), Mercy Token system.
- Month 7: Districts (4 + Abyss), encounter types (4–6 types), Mythos Exposure, Arch-Rival encounters, Unit Bonds.

Visa evidence: Begin endorsement application. Meetup talk. Rivalry Engine article. Charity partner outreach.

Phase 3: Polish + Steam Demo (Months 8–11 | November 2026–February 2027)

- Month 8: Visual overhaul — replace primitives with models, atmospheric lighting, fog, VFX.
- Month 9: Sound design. Tutorial/onboarding. Accessibility features. Game balance pass.
- Month 10: External playtesting. Bug fixing. Performance optimisation. Steam Deck testing.
- Month 11: Steam page live. Playable demo. Charity partnership finalised. Visa application completed.

Visa evidence: Conference talk. Charity LOI. Playtest testimonials. Press coverage. Steam page as portfolio.

19. POST-LAUNCH ROADMAP (CUT FEATURES)

These features were designed but deferred to post-launch to protect the 11-month deadline. Each is scoped and ready for implementation once the base game ships.

Feature	Description	Est. Dev Time	Update Type
Cursed Relics	Per-unit equipment with benefit + curse. ScriptableObject stat modifiers.	1–2 weeks	Content Update
Salvage Runs	Non-combat expeditions. Units return with loot, sanity damage, or get captured.	2–3 weeks	Major Update
Lore Fragments	Collectible text. Complete sets reveal secrets.	1 week	Content Update
Mid-Battle Phase Shifts	2–3 phases per battle. Rival enters at Phase 2. Hidden mutation at Phase 3.	2 weeks	Major Update
Rival Interrupts	Rivals call reinforcements, freeze units, activate mutations mid-battle.	1–2 weeks	Major Update
Rival-to-Rival Relationships	Alliances, Feuds, Hierarchies between rivals. Faction politics.	2–3 weeks	Expansion
Daily/Weekly Challenges	Seeded runs. Steam leaderboards. Charity Week events.	2–3 weeks	Live Service
Sanity-Fueled Ultimates	Per-class ultimate abilities charged by combat and stress.	2 weeks	Major Update
Cover & Terrain	Walls, chokepoints, cover cells. Requires pathfinding rewrite.	3–4 weeks	Expansion
Named Synergy Combos	Specific mutation pairs create named events.	3 days	Content Update
Mutation Codex	Collectible log of discovered mutations with win/loss stats.	4 days	Content Update

Visa Value of This Roadmap

A documented post-launch plan shows Tech Nation you have a 2-year product vision, not just an 11-month sprint. Each update is a future devlog post, a future press moment, and further evidence of sustained innovation in UK digital technology.

THE THREE-PILLAR TEST

Before building ANY feature, ask: does this serve AI Behaviour (Pillar 1), Psychological Simulation (Pillar 2), or the Rivalry Engine (Pillar 3)?

- If it serves one pillar: build it.
- If it connects two pillars: prioritise it.
- If it connects all three: it's the most valuable feature in the game.
- If it serves no pillar: it's scope creep. Cut it.

The Innovation Story

Pillar 1 (AI) drives combat. Gambits modify behaviour trees. Comprehension differentiates classes.
Pillar 2 (Psych) tracks mental state. Phobias link to specific trauma. Knowledge has a cost.
Pillar 3 (Rivalry) drives escalation. Rivals cause dread, horror, phobias, and exposure.

No pillar operates in isolation. Every battle touches all three.
That interconnection IS the innovation. That is what makes this game unique.
That is the story the visa application tells.